Time passed. Hour melted into hour. Minimal dilation.

Meg was doing a lot of deep breathing for pain. Then the deep breathing stopped working. She was in so much pain that she needed an epidural.

The anesthetist hurried in. Off went the music, on went the lights.

Whoa. Vibe change.

He gave her an injection at the base of her spine.

Still the pain didn't let up. The medicine apparently wasn't getting where it needed to go.

He came back, did it again.

Now things both quietened and accelerated.

Her doctor came back two hours later, slipped both hands into a pair of rubber gloves. *This is it, everybody.* I stationed myself at the head of the bed, holding Meg's hand, encouraging her. *Push, my love. Breathe.* The doctor gave Meg a small hand mirror. I tried not to look, but I had to. I glanced, saw a reflection of the baby's head emerging. Stuck. Tangled. *Oh, no, please, no.* The doctor looked up, her mouth set in a particular way. Things were getting serious.

I said to Meg: *My love, I need you to push.*

I didn't tell her why. I didn't tell her about the cord, didn't tell her about the likelihood of an emergency C-section. I just said: *Give me everything you've got.*

And she did.

I saw the little face, the tiny neck and chest and arms, wriggling, writhing. Life, life—amazing! I thought, Wow, it really all begins with a struggle for freedom.

A nurse swept the baby into a towel and placed him on Meg's chest and we both cried to see him, meet him. A healthy little boy, and he was *here*.

Our ayurvedic doctor had advised us that, in the first minute of life, a baby absorbs everything said to them. *So whisper to the baby, tell the baby your wish for him, your love. Tell.*

We told.

I don't remember phoning anyone, texting them. I remember watching the nurses run tests on my hour-old son, and then we were out of there. Into the lift, into the underground car park, into the people-carrier, and gone. Within two